that the term ‘irregular migrant’ would be used instead. A spokesman for the Myanmar government stated: ‘They can’t pressure us. We won’t accept any pressure. We need the right approach to resolve the problem’.[104] After the conference, the Indonesian navy agreed to help any boats in danger of sinking and Myanmar agreed to close its borders to prevent any further refugees leaving. There is also some evidence of other regional powers, especially Malaysia, starting to lose patience with Myanmar over the refugee problem,[105] and being prepared to call for direct intervention to stop the core cause—the persecution of the Rohingyas.

But Myanmar closing its borders does not even begin to address the problems the Rohingyas face. Myanmar has no intention of stopping the persecution of the Rohingyas, and many in the regime would like to deport the entire population to Bangladesh. The basic attitude was summed up by U Zaw Htay, a deputy director general of the Myanmar president’s office: ‘There is no change in the government’s policy toward the Bengalis’.[106] If this is so, the detention camps in Rakhine will simply become permanent prisons, and the international community will return to ignoring the problem. As could have been expected, another facet of some regime representatives’ response has been to deny that the refugees are Rohingyas.

General Min Aung Hlaing, the Myanmar military’s commander in chief, has said some ‘boat people’ landing in Malaysia and Indonesia are likely pretending to be Rohingya Muslims to receive UN aid. He suggested that ‘most victims are expected to assume themselves to be Rohingya from Myanmar in the hope of receiving assistance from UNHCR’.[107] Other government spokesmen have made a similar argument, claiming that, as a government spokesman said, ‘We cannot say the migrants are from Myanmar unless we can identify them … Most victims of human trafficking claim they are from Myanmar; it is very easy and convenient for them’.[108] Of course, as the state refuses to grant them the basics of citizenship and has been known to seize even the identity cards they do have, it is exceptionally hard for any Rohingyas to prove they have come from Myanmar.

As discussed earlier, the flow of unbiased information within Myanmar has become very limited, and many ordinary people in the country have never even become aware of the refugee crisis, due to prejudice and a lack of information within the country.[109] Thus the regime’s usual insensitivity